

The Greatest Ape

When the gods recalled the *tyrant lizards*ⁱ, the mice crawled out the ash.

And in the blink of a divine eye, some mice morphed into *monkeys*ⁱⁱ.

And when some monkeys lost their tails, so begins the tale.

...blind Tiresias gave to all...

Deep within the jungle, there grew a troop of apes. Twisted, gnarled, and peeling, their knuckles mirrored the bark of the trees in which they slept up high. One ape in particular was especially ugly. His hair was matted like the moss, black like the soil miles below. His soul was primitive, like it had the *Garden of Eden*ⁱⁱⁱ etched within. He would beat his chest so hard his corticate knuckles would leak *wine-dark*^{iv} crimson blood, painting his pecs with each consecutive pound.

...cold fists upon his naked breast...

Ugly and crude as he was, the world loved him and gave him special care. The gods favored him, perhaps out of pity. His troop had him sleep on the highest branch of the tallest of the home trees, and when he eventually took it to heart – his dark, primitive soul – that he was above the other apes, he decided to venture to the ground. Or maybe something else lured him down: the sickeningly sweet smell of the black earth, layered in rotting life, or just the weight of the air, the sky above and vast expanse below.

So, he swung through the branches, for days at a time. His calluses were wiped free from his palms, flaking off and floating down to the forest floor like leaves in the

breeze. From his palms then flowed his crimson blood, down to his wrists, where they joined the stream from his torn knuckles. There the blood pooled and slid off his wrists, one drop at a time, racing the flaked calluses to the forest floor. All the while, the ape continued his descent. His knotted hair caught on all the branches, all the way down the trunks, leaving him not near naked, but much sparser by the end.

...wax melts before a gentle fire...

When at last he reached the ground, he was far from where he had begun his journey. His calluses were still falling, or maybe they were just leaves. And his blood was finally hitting the floor, one drop at a time, like rain. For every drop that hit the ground, there were two drops of sound. This is when he first noticed the *Echo*^v that surrounded him. Looking back, he realized that maybe this Echo had shadowed him his whole life. His chest-beating had always been the loudest, as if compounded by the wind, not washed away. But maybe this Echo was fresh, a medal to commemorate his Odyssean journey.

The smell of the soil was not as sweet as it had seemed from the sky. His crimson blood continued raining from the trees, each drop releasing its copper smell into the thick air alongside its Echo. He followed the copper smell, which seemed somehow sweeter than the smell of the soil. He walked for days, on his knuckles, dragging them over the surface of the world, placing them one in front of the other, one at a time but time and time again for what seemed like all time.

...praising is praised, desiring is desired...

As he walked, his knuckles left behind more and more blood. It soaked the earth, but the black consumed the crimson and no stroke was left to taint its surface. As the earth began to saturate though, the soil would compact and harden. His blood became the water of the forest, raining from above and flowing from below. His world became a harder place as the oxisol beneath him solidified.

...no color now...

First, it became *stone*.

As he walked further, continuously saturating the ground, it turned to *bronze*.
Sunsets later, his blood turned the ground to *iron*^{vi}.

At this point, his blood was pumping through all veins of the earth, being shot into the vascular systems of every tree in the forest. They soon came tumbling down, and in their place rose stalagmites, deposits of the then concrete soil. The deposits would grow higher and higher, casting shade across what was left of the jungle.

All the while, the ape kept walking towards the sweet copper smell, the Echo of the drops. When finally he reached the source, he closed his ugly eyes^{vii} and took in the sweet, crimson smell, the only smell left. When he opened them again, he at long last gazed upon the source, a perfect pool of his blood, perfectly still and perfectly square, an oasis in the concrete jungle.

Then he saw, for the first time, in the middle of the little pool, his own reflection.

...I'll die before I yield to you...

It is unclear whether he knew it was nothing more than a reflection, if he knew there was even such a thing as a reflection, as an Echo of his entity. But when he beat his chest, the reflection mirrored his display. When the last drop of blood flew from his knuckle and landed in the pool, its Echo too flew with the same trajectory, landing in the same spot of mirrored worlds. And from that spot, the impact of those colliding drops, stemmed a ripple that altered the boundary between the worlds, even if just for a moment.

...received into the Underworld, he gazed upon himself in Styx's pool...

The ape had never seen anything more beautiful. It could not have been physical attraction that the vile, grotesque creature had for his own reflection. It must have been infatuation, rather, for the Eden etched within, for the physical manifestation of his primitive soul that was reflected back to him. It must have reminded him of times long gone, of when he left his origins behind, of those wonderful, primitive times of eons past.

When his ugly black eyes locked with the beautiful *golden*^{viii} eyes of his reflection, he knew he could not tear them away. *Doomed*^{ix}, he stayed, peering over the pool, pouring his love into the reflection. His love hit the surface of the pool and Echoed back to him, which he mistook for reciprocal love emanating from the warm, icy, crimson reflection. But his reflection was nothing more than a *siren*^x, a calling that lured him from the beginning of his time, from his very conception, to come to this pool, to destroy everything on his way.

...when a torch is lit and from the tip the leaping sulphur grasps the offered flame...

The ape could never blink, even as the gods did. As time itself passed, still he could not turn away, and his eyelids desiccated and crumbled. He could hear the concrete trees crumbling down, an homage to his eyelids, but the constant shade told him that they were being replaced. With what material is left unknown, but the shade grew ever greater, ever darker, as the ape kept staring at his love in vain. When the world turned black, it was then that the ape's reflection disappeared, then that the ape realized that everything had gone wrong. He knew, in that moment of blackness, that there was nothing that could be done, that the light was really gone.

...frightened deer...

But still he tried to get up, simply out of panic, to comfort himself through efforts to remedy his mistakes. And even this he could not do, as he had no blood left pumping through his system, none left to power his movement.

So, he had no choice but to continue staring, forced by fate itself to keep his eyes open, and look at the damage, the blackness, the nothingness, that was all his own. He looked at the black until his live corpse began to rot, to meld with the ground beneath his physicality. He weighed billions at this point, and his body dug deeper and deeper, cratering the world, until it began to waste away.

...I yield to you...

His toes first became roots as his skin became ash. So, in the middle of the crater, from the pile of ash, nourished by that damned, sweet, wine-dark crimson blood, sprouted a lone daffodil with a virgin *white*^{xi} sclera, a golden iris, and a small, primitive, infinite, black – infinitely black – pupil. And as the remaining structures came tumbling down, the gods' golden light was once again cast upon the world, the first ray reserved for that lone daffodil.

...the image is my own...

Around that lone daffodil soon sprang up a new jungle, a garden, a garden as primitive as the ape's etched soul. The Garden of Eden was finally free, and the myth of man, soon forgotten.

...I loved in vain...

ⁱ "Tyrannosaur." Merriam-Webster. Accessed May 03, 2019. <https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/tyrannosaur>.

"Tyrannosaur" is derived from Latin for "tyrant lizard."

ⁱⁱ Sellers, Bill. "Primate Evolution." October 20, 2000.

Primates, such as monkeys and great apes (including humans), evolved from small, basal mammals.

ⁱⁱⁱ *King James*. Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2003.

The Garden of Eden is a primitive paradise and a crucial component of the Christian creation myth.

^{iv} Homer, and Emily R. Wilson. *The Odyssey*. New York; London: W.W. Norton Et Company, 2018.

“Wine-dark” is the epithet Homer attributes to the sea, creating a bridge between blood red and ocean blue.

^v Melville, A. D., and Ovid. *Metamorphoses (Oxford World's Classics)*. New York, NY: Oxford University Press, 1998.

Echo is one of many suitors whom Narcissus rejects due to inflated pride.

^{vi} "The Stone, Bronze, and Iron Ages." Stone, Bronze, and Iron Ages | Essential Humanities. Accessed May 03, 2019. <http://www.essential-humanities.net/history-overview/stone-bronze-iron-ages/>.

The stone, bronze, and iron ages are chronological markers in human technological progression.

^{vii} Melville, A. D., and Ovid. *Metamorphoses (Oxford World's Classics)*. New York, NY: Oxford University Press, 1998.

When people cast their eyes upon Medusa they turn to stone, a tragic form of destruction.

^{viii} Melville, A. D., and Ovid. *Metamorphoses (Oxford World's Classics)*. New York, NY: Oxford University Press, 1998.

King Midas could turn anything to gold with just his touch.

- ^{ix} "How Caravaggio, Freud and Dalí Saw Narcissus | Art | Agenda." Phaidon. Accessed May 03, 2019.
<https://www.phaidon.com/agenda/art/articles/2018/march/19/how-caravaggio-freud-and-dali-saw-narcissus/>.

In their visual portrayals of the myth, Caravaggio, Freud, and Dalí each take unique stances on Narcissus' doom.

- ^x Homer, and Emily R. Wilson. *The Odyssey*. New York; London: W.W. Norton Et Company, 2018.

Not even Odysseus himself could resist the song of sirens.

- ^{xi} Melville, A. D., and Ovid. *Metamorphoses (Oxford World's Classics)*. New York, NY: Oxford University Press, 1998.

When Narcissus passes, a lone white daffodil, or narcissus flower, grows in his place.